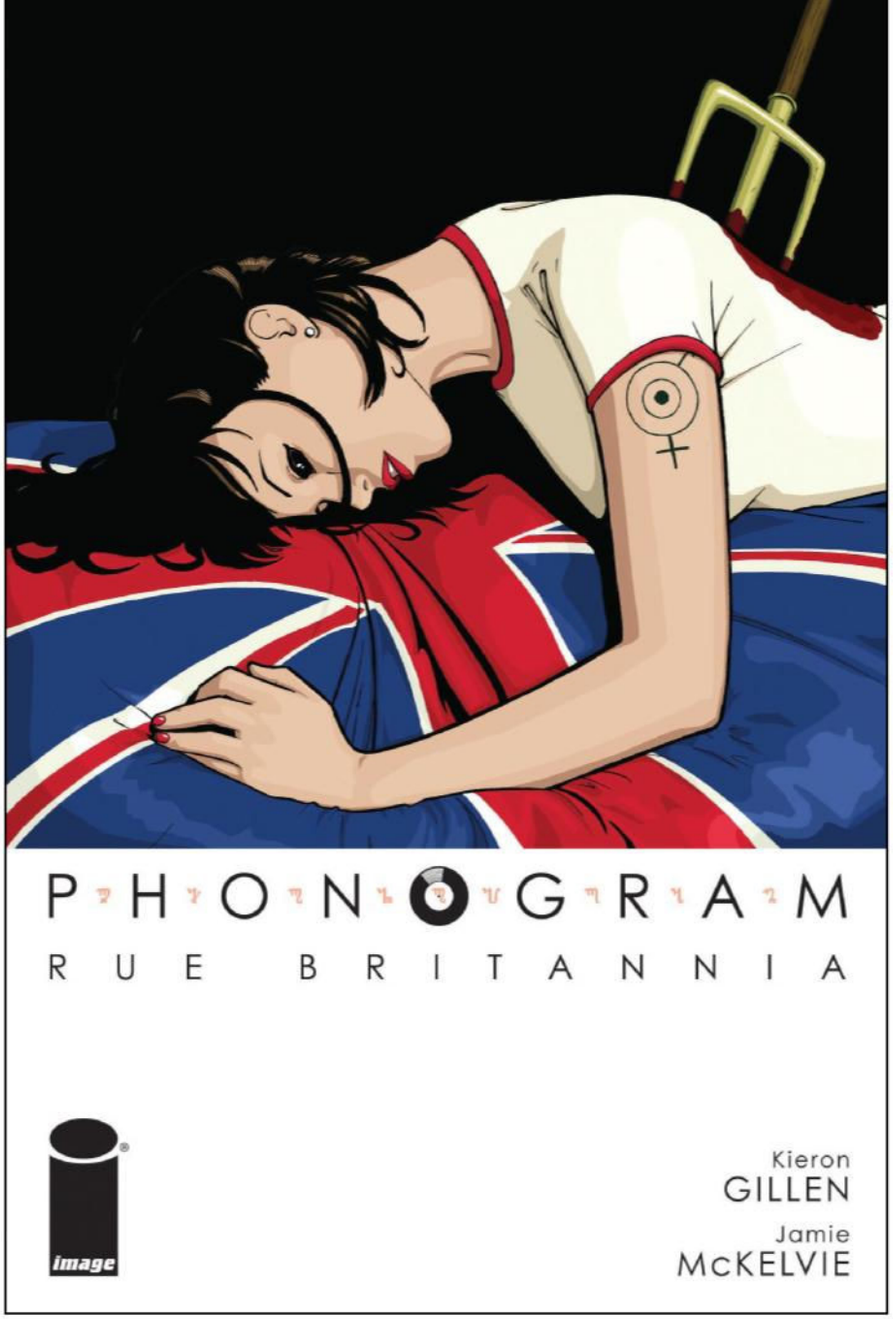


PHONOGRAM: RUE BRITANNIA

Details **Originally published** Phonogram: Vol 1 (2006) **Publisher** Image **Writer** Kieron Gillen **Artist** Jamie McKelvie **Collected in** Phonogram: Vol 1 - Rue Britannia **Available digitally** Comixology

Phonogram looks inaccessible at first – a navel-gazing sojourn through Nineties Britpop culture with references so precise they'd be obscure to anyone not *of the scene*. But Kieron Gillen's writing evokes a dark, magical fantasy out of the Britpop clique; an astute and self-deprecating reflection of the elitist musical culture of the time that ends up feeling like a cross between Nick Hornby and Stephen King – a universal tale for anyone that's ever been hung up on an ex-lover, or ignored by someone they admire.

McKelvie's art carries the gripping storyline through both time-travel and psychological change (the male protagonist is cursed to suffer periods at one point, for example) without ever feeling out of place. The minimalist black-and-white portraiture the book is composed of never ceases to impress, and McKelvie's straight-forward, no-frills decoration augments Gillen's direct and observation writing with aplomb. Fans of dark humour, musical commentary and *real* characters, take note.



